

The Essence of the Noble Vairocana

Ārya-Vairocana-hṛdaya · Toh 535 · Derge Kangyur

འཕགས་པ་རྣམ་པར་སྐྱེས་པའི་ཀུན་གྱི་ཉི་མོ་

Toh 535 in the Kangyur is a dhāraṇī text known in Tibetan as "Zla ba'i 'od" and in Sanskrit as something approximating the Candraprabha, meaning "Moonlight" in English. It belongs to the class of dhāraṇī literature, short ritual and protective scripture collections that form part of the broader dhāraṇī section of the Kangyur, and it concerns the recitation of a sacred mantra formula invoking the Tathāgata Moonlight alongside blessings of the Three Jewels. The text promises that those who recite this dhāraṇī — particularly sons and daughters of good family who do so at dawn or by moonlight — will be protected from epidemic diseases, harmful influences, and contagious illnesses, and will attain the meditative absorption known as Stainless Light. It appears immediately following the closely related Essence of the Noble Vairocana dhāraṇī, suggesting these short protective texts were transmitted and preserved together as a cluster within the canon.

All epidemic diseases, harms, and contagious illnesses shall not arise. One shall also attain the meditative absorption called Stainless Light.

This concludes the dhāraṇī called the Essence of the Noble Vairocana.

Homage to the Tathāgata, arhat, perfectly and fully awakened buddha Moonlight.

Tadyathā: candre candre su-candre mati-candra-candra-kiraṇa siri siri buddhādhiṣṭhite kili kili dharmādhiṣṭhite kili kili saṃghādhiṣṭhite svāhā.

Whatever son or daughter of good family who, rising always in the early morning, and by the light of the moon —

Translator's Notes

- The text breaks off mid-sentence at the end of the passage. The dhāraṇī syllables are rendered in standardized Sanskrit transliteration as is customary for untranslated mantra strings. The phrase "rising always in the early morning" renders "rtaḡ tu naṅ paṛ laṅs te," literally "having always arisen in the early part," meaning before dawn or at dawn; this is a standard devotional instruction to perform recitation at the start of each day.

Colophon

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Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.